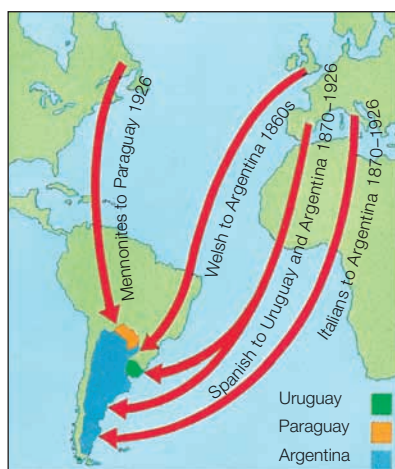


SOUTHERN SOUTH AMERICA

FROM THE TROPICAL INTERIOR OF Paraguay, through the warm Mediterranean climate of central Chile, to the freezing conditions around the glaciers of Argentina, southern South America is a region of great contrasts. Four countries – Chile, Argentina, Paraguay, and Uruguay – make up this half of the continent, often called the “southern cone” because of its shape. An important land resource is the pampas, a vast fertile plain that stretches across Argentina and Uruguay, where huge quantities of wheat are grown. During the 1970s, all four countries were known for their brutal military dictatorships. These have since been overturned, and the countries are now run as democracies.

Main migration routes from 1860–1926



MIGRANT GROUPS

Many people from Europe have settled in South America. During the 19th and early 20th centuries, poverty in Italy drove laborers to Argentina for the wheat harvest; many never went home. Workers also left Spain for Argentina and Uruguay. A German religious group, the Mennonites, moved to Paraguay from Canada to find freedom of worship, and the Welsh set up a community in Argentina to escape English rule and preserve their language.



ATACAMA DESERT

This desert in northern Chile is the driest place on Earth, often with no rain for years on end. When rain does fall, devastating flash floods are often the result. The Atacama is a barren wilderness of sun-baked rock and shifting sand dunes where the nighttime temperature can fall dramatically in just one hour. The only paved road across this desolate desert is the Pan-American Highway.



INDIAN PEOPLES

Unlike northern South America, the countries in the south have only a few native Indian groups, with Paraguay home to the largest proportion. Uruguay has no Indian population at all. The main surviving groups include the Kolla of Argentina, shown here, the Mataco and Mapuche of central and southern Chile, and the Ache, who live in Paraguay.



CATTLE BREEDING

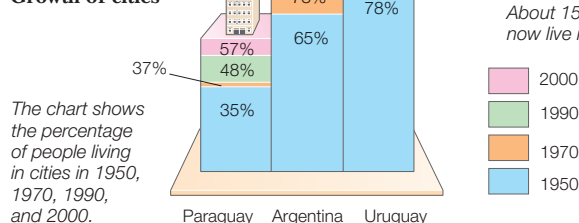
In Argentina and Uruguay, cattle breeding for beef exports is a major source of income. Vast herds of cattle graze the pampas, many feeding on alfalfa plants, which produce a leaner meat. The main breeds are Aberdeen Angus and Herefords, brought over from Europe during the last century. Sheep are grazed in the cooler area of Patagonia, and both Argentina and Uruguay are among the world's top wool-producing nations.

WHERE PEOPLE LIVE

In the past 50 years there has been a great shift as people have moved from the country to the cities in search of work. In Argentina and Uruguay, city populations were already swollen by large numbers of immigrants. In each country, the capital city has grown very quickly while the population in other cities has remained fairly small. Almost 40 percent of Argentinians, for example, live in the capital city of Buenos Aires, shown here. Since the 1970s, the move to the cities has begun to slow down.



Growth of cities



About 15 million people now live in Buenos Aires.